Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Jeffrey Harrison's "Renewal"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of controlling image in Harrison's "Renewal" include

allusion,
conceit,
contrast,
controlling image,
diction,
imagery (auditory, olfactory, tactile, visual),
irony,
metaphor,
metonymy,
onomatopoeia,
pun,
tenor,
tone, and
vehicle.

The controlling image, as the contestant should readily recognize, is the metaphor (arguably the conceit) that has the Department of Motor Vehicles being compared to a church. The metaphor runs through Harrison's poem, starting with the title, which, in the context of the church, speaks to redemption and salvation: license renewal is equated to the freedom offered by being converted into a licensed driver able to "speed[ ] down the highway, alone, / with all the windows open, singing.

The contestant might make something of the singing (line 26), which is a celebratory exercise that contrasts with "wait[ing] two hours on one of those wooden benches / like pews" (lines 2-4). He or she might understand that the lack of windows in the DMV serves as a contrast to a church's stained glass and to the imagined car's open windows. The contrast that characterizes the relationship between the tenor (the DMV) and the vehicle (a church) is found throughout the poem; e.g., the stale cigarette smoke is compared to incense, the automated voice is compared to a sermon, the traffic fines are indulgences that offset "wrong turns"; "piloting our own journey" is at once the driving of a car and the living of a life, once we are licensed or redeemed.

The fullness of the controlling image's vehicle is found in the threading of church imagery, which begins with the allusory "Latter Day Meaninglessness," through *pews*, *stained glass*, *incense*, *sermon*, *congregation*, *altar*, *redemption*, *indulgences*, *piloting* of a journey, and *transformed*, ending with *singing*.